Twinkle Toes

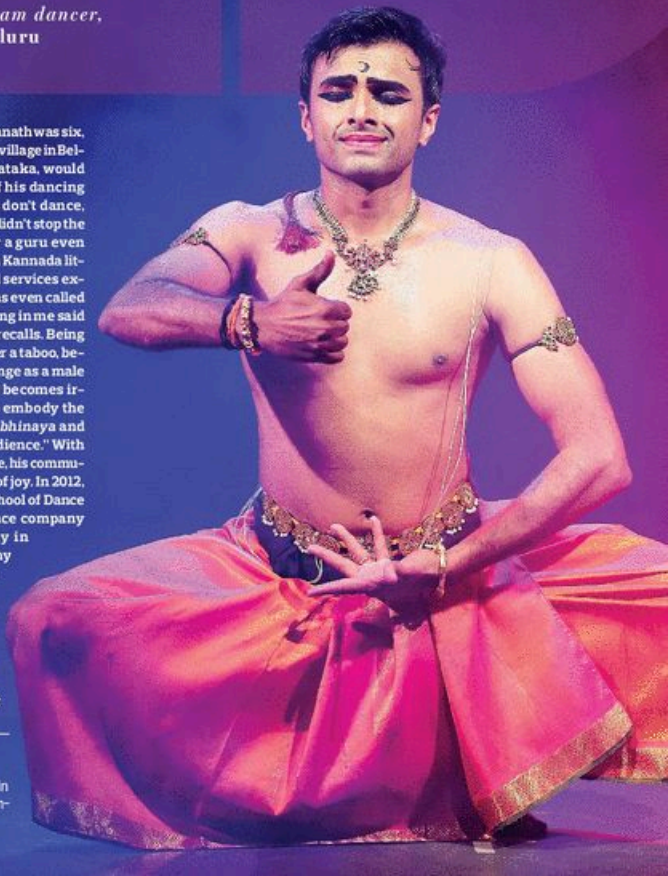
PARSHWANATH UPADHYE, 39

Bharatanatyam dancer, **Bengaluru**

THE NEXT 100
DANCE

"Parshwanath is perfection and poise. Centred. Classy. A joy to watch"

–Ashish Mohan Khokar
Dance historian



When Parshwanath was six, people in his village in Belgaum, Karnataka, would make fun of his dancing the Bharatanatyam. Boys don't dance, they would mock. But that didn't stop the young dancer's search for a guru even as he pursued a master's in Kannada literature and sat for the civil services examination, for which he was even called for an interview. "Something in me said dance was my calling," he recalls. Being a male dancer was no longer a taboo, besides. "It has been a challenge as a male dancer, but I feel the body becomes irrelevant if you are able to embody the character through your *abhinaya* and convey that rasa to the audience." With an eclectic presence on stage, his communication technique is that of joy. In 2012, he started the Upadhye School of Dance in Bengaluru and the dance company Punyah Dance Company in 2013. "I want to go back to my roots, my village to propagate dance," he says. He is also building a dance gurukul in Belgaum where he expects to teach and inspire the young to take up dance. ■

– S. Sahaya Ranjit

ALL ROUNDER
Parshwanath is a black belt in karate and a swimming champion. He has also trained in Kalaripayattu.